

Radionuclide therapy for medullary thyroid cancer

This treatment uses a radioactive substance to destroy the cancer. It is not often used to treat medullary thyroid cancer (MTC).

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What is radionuclide therapy for medullary thyroid cancer?

Radionuclide therapy is a type of [internal radiotherapy](#). It uses a radioactive substance, which is attached to a type of chemical. It is not often used to treat [medullary thyroid cancer \(MTC\)](#). It is more common to have [targeted therapies](#). Your doctor will explain more about this treatment if they think it is suitable for you.

Radionuclide therapy is not the same as [radioactive iodine](#) which is used to treat [papillary and follicular thyroid cancer](#).

How does radionuclide therapy work?

Radionuclide therapy use a radioactive substance, which is attached to a type of chemical, to destroy the cancer. Some MTCs absorb large amounts of certain chemicals.

How will I have radionuclide therapy

You will have a scan that uses a tiny amount of radioactive substance. It tests whether the tumour absorbs a large amount of these chemicals. If it does, you have the treatment using a higher dose of the radioactive substance.

The treatment is given as a drip into a vein. As the chemical is absorbed, you also absorb the radioactivity. This destroys cancer cells.

It is a radioactive substance, so you will have it in a special ward. You will be looked after in a room on your own. This is so that other people are not exposed to the radioactivity. Your doctor will explain more about this treatment and any safety precautions you need to take.

Getting support

Macmillan is here to support you. If you would like to talk, you can do the following:

- Call the Macmillan Support Line for free on [0808 808 00 00](tel:0808 808 00 00)
- [Chat to our specialists online](#).
- Visit our [radiotherapy and side effects forum](#) to talk to people who have been affected by radiotherapy, share your experience, and ask an expert your questions.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our medullary thyroid cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at

informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

Get in touch

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



0300 1000 200

Our Support Line is available Monday to Friday, 9:30am-4:30pm



Email us

Email the Macmillan Fundraising team if you have any questions.



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